Social Transformation in Tamil Nadu

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Introduction:

✓ In the late 18th century, Europeans took control of the Indian subcontinent.

✓ By the early 19th century, the British began changing Indian society through new land policies and by trying to spread their culture and values. This made many educated Indians feel humiliated.

✓ In response, they looked to their own history and culture for identity and began working to reform their society.

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DEPARTMENT OF EMPLOYMENT AND TRAINING

TNPSC Group IV – History, Culture, Heritage, and Socio-Political Movements of Tamil Nadu Mindmap

Tamil Renaissance & Social Transformation

- Colonialism and humanism brought major cultural and social changes in India.
- Tamil Nadu underwent a transformation, with language and literature helping build Tamil identity

🖨️ Advent of Printing Technology

- Tamil became the first non-European language to be printed (*Thambiran Vanakkam*, 1578).
- **Ziegenbalg established a** printing press in Tranquebar (1709).
- Early printed works were religious, but secular texts soon followed.

📚 Rediscovery of Tamil Classics

- Thirukkural published in 1812 encouraged scholars to preserve ancient texts.
- C.W. Damotharanar and U.V. Swaminathar were key figures:
    - Collected palm-leaf manuscripts.
    - Published classics like ***Silappathikaram***, *Manimekalai*, *Paththupattu*, and more.
- Helped create awareness of Tamil history, culture, and literature.

🧠 Linguistic Identity & Dravidian Theory

- **F.W. Ellis (1816): South Indian languages are not related to Indo-Aryan languages.**
- **Robert Caldwell (1856):** Wrote *A Comparative Grammar of Dravidian Languages*, proving Tamil's antiquity and uniqueness.
- Tamil seen as a Dravidian, egalitarian, and non-Brahmin language.

🌱 Cultural & Social Awakening

- Revival of Sangam literature became the foundation of Tamil cultural pride.
- Writers and thinkers emphasized Tamil/Dravidian vs Sanskrit/Aryan distinctions.
- The play ***Manonmaniam*** by **P. Sundaranar inclu**des a Tamil invocation song celebrating this heritage.

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✊ Key Reformers & Thinkers

- Ramalinga Adigal (Vallalar): Criticized caste and religious orthodoxy.
- **Abraham Pandithar: Promoted Tamil music.**
- Thiru. Vi. Ka, Subramania Bharathi, Bharathidasan: Advocated for equality and Tamil pride through literature.
- Parithimar Kalaignar, Maraimalai Adigal, S. Vaiyapuri: Worked to purify Tamil and promote its use.

Tani Tamil Iyakkam (Pure Tamil Movement)

- Led by **Maraimalai Adigal**: Promoted pure Tamil by removing Sanskrit words.
- Changed his name from **Vedachalam** to a pure Tamil one.
- His daughter **Neelambikai** created a dictionary with Tamil equivalents for Sanskrit terms.

🟣 Dravidian Movement

- Started as a resistance to Brahmin dominance in colonial society.
- Madras Non-Brahmin Association (1909) and Madras United League (1912) helped uplift non-Brahmins.
- Iyotheethassar, M. Singaravelar, and Periyar E.V. Ramasamy advocated for social justice, equality, and rationalism



Parithimar Kalaignar

❖ V.G. Suryanarayana Sastri (Parithimar Kalaignar)
↓
❖ Born near Madurai (1870)
↓
❖ Professor of Tamil at Madras Christian College
↓
❖ Recognized Sanskrit influence on Tamil
↓

- → Adopted the pure Tamil name **"Parithimar Kalaignar"**
- ↓
- → First to demand Tamil be recognized as a "Classical Language"
- ↓
- → Opposed calling Tamil a "**vernacular**" language
- ↓
- → Introduced sonnet form in Tamil (inspired by Western literature)
- ↓
- → Wrote novels, plays & scientific essays
- ↓
- Died young at 33 (1903)



Maraimalai Adigal

- Maraimalai Adigal (Father of Tani Tamil Iyakkam)
- ↓
- Born as Vedachalam (1876)
- ↓
- → Changed name to **"Maraimalai Adigal" (pure Tamil)**
- ↓
- → Worked in **Siddhanta Deepika journal**
- ↓
- → Tamil teacher at Madras Christian College
- ↓
- → Influenced by **P. Sundaranar & Somasundara Nayagar**
- ↓
- Wrote commentaries on Sangam texts: **Pattinappalai & Mullaipattu**
- **Tani Tamil Iyakkam (Pure Tamil Movement)**
- ↓
- Founded by **Maraimalai Adigal**
- ↓
- Goal: Remove Sanskrit influence from Tamil
- ↓
- → Promoted **"pure Tamil"** vocabulary

↓

❖ → Renamed his journal *Jnanasagaram* to *Arivukkadal*

↓

❖ → Rebranded institution from *Samarasa Sanmarga Sangam* to *Pothu Nilai Kalakam*

↓

❖ → Daughter **Neelambikai compiled dictionary of Tamil equivalents to Sanskrit words**

↓

❖ Impact: Greatly influenced Tamil literature, language, and cultural identity

Rise of the Dravidian Movement

Brahmin dominance in social, educational, and political spheres

↓

Emergence of Dravidian Movement to defend Non-Brahmin interests

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1909: Formation of Madras Non-Brahmin Association

1912: Dr. C. Natesanar founds Madras United League

↓

Renamed as Madras Dravidian Association (to support Dravidian uplift)

↓

Key Objectives:

- Educate and support Non-Brahmin graduates

- Conduct regular meetings to share grievances

↓

1916: Establishment of Dravidian Home Hostel at **Triplicane (Madras)**

↓

Purpose of **Dravidian Home:**

- Provide hostel facilities for Non-Brahmin students

- Promote educational development

- Host literary society for Non-Brahmin students

So

TNPSC Group IV – History, Culture, Heritage, and Socio-Political Movements of Tamil Nadu Mindmap

Formation	**1916**
Founders	Dr. C. Natesanar, Sir Pitti Theyagarayar, T.M. Nair, Alamelu Mangai Thayarammal
venue	December 1916: Release of Non-Brahmin Manifesto at Victoria Public Hall
Publication of Newspapers:	Dravidian (Tamil) - Justice (English) - Andhra Prakasika (Telugu)
Election	1920: First Election under Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms (Dyarchy system)
Justice Party	Justice Party wins election → Forms government in Madras Presidency - Chief Minister: A. Subbarayalu - Government tenure: 1920–1923 and 1923–1926 - Continues till 1937 due to Congress boycott 1937: Indian National Congress contests and defeats Justice Party
Key Programmes and Achievements:	Expanded education and employment opportunities for majority - Removed legal barriers for inter-caste marriages - Allowed Depressed Classes access to public wells, tanks, and schools - Established hostels for Depressed Classes (1923) - Allowed women's participation in electoral politics (1921) → Muthulakshmi Ammaiyar becomes first woman legislator (1926) - Passed Communal Government Orders (1921, 1922) for reservation in jobs - Established Staff Selection Board (1924), model for Public Service Commission (1929) - Hindu Religious Endowment Act (1926) for caste-neutral temple management

Self-Respect Movement & Periyar E.V.R.

Formation	**1925: Formation of Self-Respect Movement by Periyar E.V.R**
Objectives	Promote rationalism and self-respect - Create a casteless society - End rituals and superstitions - Emphasize women's education and emancipation - Advocate for self-respect marriages
Periyar's Publications	Kudi Arasu (1925) - Revolt - Puratchi (1933) - Paguththarivu (1934) - Viduthalai (1935)
Collaborations & Influence:	Supported Vaikom Satyagraha → called **"Vaikom Virar"** - Opposed caste-discrimination at Cheranmadevi Gurukulam - Worked with Singaravelar (Buddhist and Communist leader) - Translated **Ambedkar's *Annihilation of Caste*** into Tamil (1936)
Anti-Hindi Agitation (1937–1939)	Protested compulsory Hindi in schools - Imprisoned for protests - Became President of the Justice Party while in jail 1944: Justice Party + Self-Respect Movement = ****Dravidar Kazhagam (DK)**** Opposition to Rajaji's "Kula Kalvi Thittam" (1953–54) - Criticized caste-based education scheme - Resulted in resignation of Rajaji - Kamaraj became Chief Minister
Periyar as Feminist Reformer	Opposed child marriage & devadasi system - Supported women's right to divorce and property - Advocated use of term "valkaithunai" (life partner) over "giving in marriage" - Wrote **"Why the Woman is Enslaved?"**

Legacy	Died in 1973 at age 94, buried at Periyar Thidal, Madras - 1989: Tamil Nadu enacts Hindu Succession Amendment Act → Ensures equal inheritance rights for women



Rettaimalai Srinivasan

Rettaimalai Srinivasan (1859–1945)

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🎯 **Contributions:**

- Fought against untouchability and caste oppression
- Worked for civil rights and social justice of the oppressed

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🏛️ **Key Initiatives:**

- 1893: Founded **Adi Dravida Mahajana Sabha**
- President of:
  - Scheduled Castes Federation
  - Madras Provincial Depressed Classes Federation

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📜 **Autobiography:**

- *Jeeviya Saritha Surukkam* (1939) — one of the earliest autobiographies

↓

🌍 **International Participation:**

- Attended **1st & 2nd Round Table Conferences** (London, 1930–31)
- Signatory to the **Poona Pact (1932)** with Dr. B.R. Ambedkar

↓

🏅 **Honours:**

- Rao Sahib (1926)
- Rao Bahadur (1930)
- Divan Bahadur (1936)



M.C. Rajah

M.C. Rajah (1883–1943)

↓

🎓 **Background:**

- Teacher and textbook writer
- From the **"Depressed Class"**

↓

🏛️ **Political Involvement:**

- Founding Member of **Justice Party (SILF)**
- First elected **Legislative Council Member (1920–26)**
- **Deputy Leader of Justice Party in Madras Legislative Council**

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🌐 **National Platform:**

- 1928: Founded ****All India Depressed Classes Association****
- Longtime leader advocating Dalit rights across India

⚙️ ***Labour Movement Begins:***

- Rise in labour unrest

- Formation of labour unions in Madras Presidency

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👥 Key Leaders:

- B.P. Wadia

- M. Singaravelar

- Thiru. Vi. Kalyanasundaram

↓

🏭 Major Milestones:

- **1918: Formation of **Madras Labour Union****

(India's first organised trade union)

- **1920: First **All India Trade Union Conference (AITUC)** held in Bombay**

• Demanded police protection, unemployment register, food export limits, injury compensation, and health insurance



M. Singaravelar

M. Singaravelar (1860–1946)

↓

🎓 Background:

- Educated at Presidency College, Madras

- Multilingual scholar; wrote on Marx, Darwin, Spencer, Einstein

- Early advocate of Buddhism

↓

🎯 Contributions:

- Leader in Labour and Communist movements

- Closely associated with **Periyar and Self-Respect Movement**

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🏢 **Landmark Achievement:**

- **1923: Organised first May Day celebration in India (Chennai)**

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📰 **Media:**

- Published **Thozhilalan** (Tamil newspaper for workers)

Women's Movements in Tamil Nadu

🏛️ Early 20th Century Context

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📢 Need for Women's Empowerment

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👩‍🏫 **Key Organisations:**

• **Women's India Association (WIA)– 1917**

- Founded by Annie Besant, Margaret Cousins, Dorothy Jinarajadasa

- Focus: Personal hygiene, marriage laws, voting rights, childcare

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• **All India Women's Conference (AIWC) – 1927**

- Focus: Women's education, policy recommendations

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💪 Support from Self-Respect Movement:

- Led by Periyar E.V.R.

- Advocated: Gender equality, rational marriages, property rights for women

↓

🤷‍♀️ **Prominent Women Activists:**

- Muthulakshmi Ammaiyar

- Nagammai
- Kannamma
- Muvalur Ramamirtham
- Nilambikai, Rukmani Ammal, Sivakami Chidambaranar